at its best during the R.N. Kao and Indira Gandhi's period, and its worst period was when the Janata Party government led by Morarji Desai was in power. There was almost a complete breakdown of the relationship in the years Desai served as the prime minister, thanks to a mutual sense of distrust. Direct communication between the R&AW and the prime minister was just 2-3 per cent of what it ought to have been—and it would have been even less if not for the institutional set up. According to a seasoned spy codenamed Rita Wadhawa, bureaucrats don't understand the need for intelligence, so they can't appreciate the products of spycraft.

'The major problem is that they treat the R&AW like any other government department,' she said. 'You ask for a post and the bureaucrats will point to other organisations to demonstrate the existence of a sanctioned strength. If we asked for fifteen positions for Mazar-i-Sharif, the bureaucrats told us to justify the number. We argued with the cabinet secretary and officials in the Prime Minister's Office that certain requirements cannot be put on file in black and white because we are not an ordinary institution. Even financial advisors posted with R&AW can be major obstacles in certain projects. They don't have the expertise of espionage and their primary responsibility is to create roadblocks.'

'The same jagged relationship exists between R&AW operatives abroad and the staff at diplomatic missions. The civilian officers posted abroad suspect that the intelligence agency spies on them, which is absolutely baseless,' Rita said. The R&AW plays no role in vigilance, but the hostility persists.

'Suppose the cover of the counsellor of information is given to an officer from the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). In that